

You will need to notify the [Department of Home Affairs](#) and the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (the department) of your intention to import a vessel prior to arrival.

The department requirements are to ensure that any biosecurity risks associated with the vessel are identified and managed. The risk of imported vessels is assessed on the basis of the travel history of the vessel, the amount of timber on board, age of the vessel, whether it has been repaired or refitted, the complexity of construction and limited access for timber inspections.

All vessels containing timber components will be inspected on arrival into Australia. Any applicable fees and charges for the inspection are set out in the department's [charging guidelines](#).

Contact the [Department of Home Affairs](#) to obtain information on duties and tax payable.

High risk vessels are those that have more than a basic amount of timber in the construction and fit-out (e.g. beams, bearers, hull, decking, railings, cabins and/or masts) and have been either manufactured/re-fitted in its history OR spent three or more months (cumulative) in high risk countries.

As examples, the department considers high risk vessels to include (but are not restricted to):

- older style yachts or other vessels with timber masts and timber hulls
- some fibreglass hulled vessels with extensive solid timber and/or marine ply internal fit-outs (such as solid timber and ply framing used under flooring, ceilings and walls).

A high risk vessel is also any vessel with evidence to suggest active termite infestations.

High risk vessels are required to undergo a timber inspection. The nature and type of inspection required will be determined by the department on the documents presented on arrival, and will be assessed according to the complexity of the vessel.

For vessels, a high risk country is one that presents a high biosecurity risk for exotic drywood termite infestation.

Minimum 10 years or for the life of the vessel (if less than 10 years old). For more information on the department's requirements please refer to the [Biosecurity Import Conditions system \(BICON\)](#).

Departmental officers will perform risk assessments based on documentation and/or inspection to determine if your vessel is low risk or high risk.

Low risk vessels may be released if no other biosecurity intervention is required.

High risk vessels will be required to undergo an inspection which may include:

- visual timber inspection/ confirmation by a departmental inspector or departmental entomologist
- timber vessel inspection by an [accredited supplier](#) of termite detector dog services, with or without a departmental officer in attendance

- timber vessel inspection by an [accredited supplier](#) of alternative termite detection services with a departmental accredited timber vessel inspector or departmental entomologist in attendance
- treatment using a departmental approved method.

[Accredited supplier](#) are companies who have obtained accreditation from the department to provide detector dog services for termite detection.

Enquiries relating to the costs of this service are obtained from the provider. The department is unable to provide this information.

An inspection will be carried out on arrival for returning Australian vessels by the departmental officer just like any other vessel entering Australian waters. The inspection will determine whether the vessel presents a low or high biosecurity risk for exotic timber pests.

There are two main pathways through which termites can infest vessels:

- Infested timber used in construction or refit, or
- Termites flying onto a vessel.

In order to make the departmental inspection process more efficient, it is important that the vessel is prepared in such a way that makes it accessible for inspection. For example:

- the vessel should be secured in such a way that prevents excessive movement during the inspection
- remove all hazardous items
- access needs to be provided to all timber surfaces
- remove all panels, stored food, personal effects and other equipment from lockers/cupboards

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/aircraft-vessels-military/vessels/non-commercial-vessels/questions-and-answers>